

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/12: The 1984 mandate and modernising agenda

MANDATE -> DECEMBER 1984; RAJIV GANDHI wins about 415 of 543 seats

AGENDA -> telecom, computerisation, science missions, panchayati raj

CAUTION -> panchayati raj not yet constitutional; that comes in the 1990s

SIGNIFICANCE -> the largest mandate in Indian electoral history to date

MUST REMEMBER: Rajiv Gandhi's December 1984 victory (Congress 404 of 514 elected seats), the 52nd Amendment and Punjab/Assam accords of 1985, Shah Bano reversal and Bofors controversy, the 1989 National Front coalition, Mandal implementation and Advani's rath yatra in 1990, the 1991 reforms, Babri Masjid demolition on 6 December 1992 and coalition governments from 1996 form separate stages.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/12: The 1985 accords and the Anti-Defection Act

PUNJAB ACCORD -> Rajiv Gandhi and Harchand Singh Longowal, 1985

ASSAM AND MIZORAM ACCORDS -> also settled in 1985

ANTI-DEFECTION ACT -> 52nd Constitutional Amendment, 1985

EFFECT -> three inherited regional crises addressed by negotiation

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/12: The twin identity concessions

CONCESSION 1 -> Shah Bano reversal, 1985-86, conservative pressure

CONCESSION 2 -> Ayodhya shrine opening, meant to balance concession 1

RESULT -> both communities alienated, not balanced

LESSON -> symbolic concessions to two sides do not cancel; they mobilise both

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/12: Bofors and the exit of V.P. Singh

BOFORS SCANDAL -> breaks in 1987; wrecks Rajiv Gandhi's "Mr Clean" image

V.P. SINGH -> exits Congress; forms the JAN MORCHA, 1987

NEXT STEP -> JANATA DAL / NATIONAL FRONT formed, 1988

OUTCOME -> Congress's own clean-government idiom turned against it

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/12: 1989: fragmentation of the party system

CONGRESS -> falls from the 1984 record to about 197 seats

BJP -> rises from 2 seats (1984) to 86 seats (1989)

GOVERNMENT -> V.P. Singh's National Front, a MINORITY government

SUPPORT -> from OUTSIDE, by both the BJP and the Left

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/12: Mandal, 1990: the caste axis

COMMISSION -> Mandal Commission recommendations implemented, 1990

QUOTA -> 27 per cent reservation for OBCs in central government jobs

TOTAL -> reservation moves toward about 49.5 per cent with SC/ST quotas

EFFECT -> nationwide agitation; OBC identity becomes an organised bloc

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/12: Mandir, 1990: the religious axis

MOBILISATION -> Advani's rath yatra, 1990, intensifies Ayodhya agitation

PARALLEL -> runs alongside, and competes with, the Mandal announcement

CULMINATION -> Babri Masjid demolished, 6 DECEMBER 1992

EFFECT -> Hindutva mobilisation becomes a national electoral force

ASCI MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/12: System-change engine: 1984 to 1999

1984 -> single-party record majority

1985-89 -> identity misjudgements plus Bofors erode support; 1989 fragments

1990 -> Mandal (caste) and Mandir (religion) mobilise differently

1991-99 -> crisis-led reform, then coalition government as the normal form

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/12: 1991: the economic break

GOVERNMENT -> Narasimha Rao takes office, 1991

POLICY -> economic liberalisation, Manmohan Singh as Finance Minister

TRIGGER -> a balance-of-payments crisis, not a prior political consensus

CONCURRENT -> Rajiv Gandhi assassinated during the same election campaign

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/12: The coalition decade, 1996-99

1996 -> a short BJP government under Atal Bihari Vajpayee

1996-98 -> United Front governments, Deve Gowda then Gujral

1998 -> National Democratic Alliance (NDA) formed, under Vajpayee

1999 -> the NDA consolidated after the general election

CLOSE DISTINCTION: The Anti-Defection Act belongs to Rajiv's 1985 government, the 27-per-cent Mandal measure concerned OBC reservation in central government employment, the 1991 reforms were crisis-led under Narasimha Rao and Manmohan Singh, and 1990's yatra must not be confused with the 1992 demolition.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 11/12: Comparative cleavages: Mandal versus Mandir

AXIS		MANDAL		MANDIR
CLEAVAGE		caste		religion
YEAR		1990		1990 (yatra), 1992 (demolition)
RESULT		crossing lines; neither yields a national majority alone		
EVIDENCE LIMIT: Election returns, amendment and accord texts, court-legislative sequences, budget/reform documents and attributed 'Mandal, Mandir and Market' interpretation must qualify both a simple modernisation story and a communal or caste-essentialist account.				

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 12/12: Three-transitions thesis

TRANSITION 1 -> single-party majority to coalition government

TRANSITION 2 -> state-led planning to a liberalised economy

TRANSITION 3 -> Congress cross-class consensus to caste/religious identity

VERDICT -> the interaction of the three explains the decade best